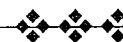


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12

Qualitative Data Analysis for Applied Policy Research

Jane Ritchie and Liz Spencer



The last two decades have seen a notable growth in the use of qualitative methods for applied social policy research. Qualitative research is now used to explore and understand a diversity of social and public policy issues, either as an independent research strategy or in combination with some form of statistical inquiry. The wider use of qualitative methods has come about for a number of reasons but is underpinned by the persistent requirement in social policy fields to understand complex behaviours, needs, systems and cultures.

'Framework', the analytic approach described in this chapter, was developed in the context of conducting applied qualitative research. It was initiated in a specialist qualitative research unit based within an

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independent social research institute (Social and Community Planning Research [SCPR]). The work of the institute spans all areas of social and public policy and is undertaken on behalf of central or local government, voluntary organizations, universities, or other public bodies, or it is grant funded by research councils and foundations. All the institute's work can be broadly classified as applied policy research, some of which is initiated by institute members but most of which is generated by the sponsoring bodies.

'Framework' has been refined and developed over the years but the general principles of the approach have proved to be versatile across a wide range of studies. Our aim here is to describe the method in detail; we use examples to show how the approach can be used to move through the various stages of the analytic process. Because the method has been developed for applied policy research, we begin with a brief overview of the kinds of objectives and requirements this sets.

❖ THE NATURE OF APPLIED POLICY RESEARCH

Applied research can be broadly distinguished from 'basic' or 'theoretical' research through its requirements to meet specific information needs and its potential for actionable outcomes. The social policy field makes use of both applied and basic research, but a great deal is of the former kind. However, a very high proportion of applied policy research is quantitative in form, a heritage from the early years of empirical social inquiry and the result of the dominant requirement of policy-makers for facts (Bulmer, 1982: 40-49). Fortunately, this is changing, as is the role played by qualitative methods. At one time, the use of qualitative methods was seen as acceptable if it was confined to a developmental role for statistical investigation. Now it has become recognized that the contributions of qualitative research are much more wide-ranging and that it has an important place in its own right. Most significantly it has a key role to play in providing insights, explanations and theories of social behaviour.

What qualitative research can offer the policy maker is a theory of social action grounded on the experiences—the world view—of those likely to be affected by a policy decision or thought to be part of the problem. (Walker, 1985: 19)

In applied policy research, qualitative methods are used to meet a variety of different objectives. The questions that need to be addressed will vary from study to study but broadly they can be divided into four categories: contextual, diagnostic, evaluative and strategic:

Contextual: identifying the form and nature of what exists

e.g. What are the dimensions of attitudes or perceptions that are held?

What is the nature of people's experiences?

What needs does the population of the study have?

What elements operate within a system?

Diagnostic: examining the reasons for, or causes of, what exists

e.g. What factors underlie particular attitudes or perceptions?

Why are decisions or actions taken, or not taken?

Why do particular needs arise?

Why are services or programmes not being used?

Evaluative: appraising the effectiveness of what exists

e.g. How are objectives achieved?

What affects the successful delivery of programmes or services?

How do experiences affect subsequent behaviours?

What barriers exist to systems operating?

Strategic: identifying new theories, policies, plans or actions

e.g. What types of services are required to meet needs?

What actions are needed to make programmes or services more effective?

How can systems be improved?

What strategies are required to overcome newly defined problems?

Most research attempts to address more than one of these groups of questions. But in applied policy research, the objectives are usually clearly set and shaped by specific information requirements. Hence any output from the research needs to be appropriately targeted towards providing 'answers', in the form of greater illumination or understanding of the issues being addressed. This in turn has important implications for the form and functions of the analysis undertaken.

In addition to the research objectives, there are other features of applied policy research which may shape the way analysis is undertaken. First, time-scales tend to be shorter rather than longer—usually

months rather than years. If government departments and other public agencies are to maximize their use of research, then they need 'answers' in time to influence their policy or planning decisions. Although all public bodies do commission longer-term research, a high proportion has a specified deadline, related to some key activity in the policy process.

Partly as a consequence of limited time-scales, applied research is often carried out by teams of researchers. These may comprise researchers from different disciplines, or be organized to allow individuals to take responsibility for different parts of the research process. Either way, this requires an explicit research methodology which can be viewed, discussed and operated by individuals within the team.

Another common feature is the need for generated data. Although desk research or document analysis usually forms part of a social policy research project (and occasionally is confined to these approaches alone), it is more usual to find that new data are collected. This may be in the form of individual interviews, group discussions or observational work. Certainly, within SCPR, most of the studies have newly generated interview data (either individual or group) and sometimes an observational component.

Qualitative research meets quite different objectives from quantitative research, and provides a distinctive kind of information. For applied policy purposes it may therefore be carried out with some kind of linkage to statistical inquiry (i.e. to help develop, illuminate, explain or qualify statistical research), or it may be entirely independent. Either way, it is important that the particular contributions that qualitative research can make are fully exploited.

Finally, there is an important issue to address in relationship to the visibility of qualitative methods. One of the factors that has almost certainly inhibited the greater use of qualitative methods in social policy fields is the lack of access that commissioners and funders have to the research process. This is particularly so in the conduct of qualitative data analysis. If decisions or actions are to be based on qualitative research, then policy-makers and practitioners need to know how the findings of the research have been obtained. The research community needs to respond to this by making its methods more explicit. This will bring not only greater confidence in the methodology, but also a deeper

understanding of what qualitative research can do, and the way in which it can do it.

❖ AIMS OF QUALITATIVE DATA ANALYSIS

Material collected through qualitative methods is invariably unstructured and unwieldy. A high proportion of it is text based, consisting of verbatim transcriptions of interviews or discussions, field notes or other written documents. Moreover, the internal content of the material is usually in detailed and micro form (e.g. accounts of experiences, descriptions of interchanges, observations of interactions, etc.). The qualitative researcher has to provide some coherence and structure to this cumbersome data set while retaining a hold of the original accounts and observations from which it is derived. All of this has implications for the methods of analysis which are developed.

Qualitative data analysis is essentially about detection, and the tasks of defining, categorizing, theorizing, explaining, exploring and mapping are fundamental to the analyst's role. The methods used for qualitative analysis therefore need to facilitate such detection, and to be of a form which allows certain functions to be performed. These functions will vary depending on the research questions being addressed, but, certainly in applied policy research, the following are frequently included:

- Defining concepts: understanding internal structures;
- Mapping the range, nature and dynamics of phenomena;
- Creating typologies: categorizing different types of attitudes, behaviours, motivations, etc.;
- Finding associations: between experiences and attitudes, between attitudes and behaviours, between circumstances and motivations, etc.;
- Seeking explanations: explicit or implicit;
- Developing new ideas, theories or strategies.

'Framework' has been developed to help these aims and outputs to be achieved. It is also designed to facilitate systematic analysis within the demands and constraints of applied policy research previously cited. To both these ends, the method has certain key features, which were central to its development. These are summarized in Figure 12.1.

Grounded or generative: it is heavily based in, and driven by, the original accounts and observations of the people it is about.

Dynamic: it is open to change, addition and amendment throughout the analytic process.

Systematic: it allows methodical treatment of all similar units of analysis.

Comprehensive: it allows a full, and not partial or selective, review of the material collected.

Enables easy retrieval: it allows access to, and retrieval of, the original textual material.

Allows between- and within-case analysis: it enables comparisons between, and associations within, cases to be made.

Accessible to others: the analytic process, and the interpretations derived from it, can be viewed and judged by people other than the primary analyst.

Figure 12.1 Key Features of 'Framework'

❖ 'FRAMEWORK' AS A METHOD OF QUALITATIVE DATA ANALYSIS

'Framework' is an analytical process which involves a number of distinct though highly interconnected stages. Although the process is presented as following a particular order—indeed some stages do logically precede others—there is no implication that 'Framework' is a purely mechanical process, a foolproof recipe with a guaranteed outcome. On the contrary, although systematic and disciplined, it relies on the creative and conceptual ability of the analyst to determine meaning, salience and connections. Real leaps in analytical thinking often involve both jumping ahead and returning to rework earlier ideas. The strength of an approach like 'Framework' is that by following a well-defined procedure, it is possible to reconsider and rework ideas precisely because the analytical process has been documented and is therefore accessible.

The approach involves a systematic process of sifting, charting and sorting material according to key issues and themes. In order to illustrate the method, and to reflect the context and diversity of its applications in applied social policy research, five studies are referenced, one or two for each stage of the analytical process. Table 12.1 outlines the aims, sample, type of data and time-scale for each study.

The five key stages to qualitative data analysis involved in 'Framework' are:

Table 12.1 Summary of Research Studies
Used for Illustrative Purposes

<i>The Study</i>	<i>Type</i>	<i>Aims or Objectives</i>	<i>Sample</i>	<i>Type of Data</i>	<i>Time-Scale</i>
<i>Talking About Sex*</i>	Contextual	To explore sexual attitudes and behaviours. To study perceived links between sexual practices and health. To develop issues and clarify language for survey.	40 individuals	Depth interviews	10 months
<i>Thirty Families*</i>	Contextual	To explore the processes that lead to changes in living standards and the impact of these changes on families.	30 families	Depth interviews, 2 interviews per family	2 phases (9 months) with interval of 5 years
<i>Barriers to the Receipt of Dental Care*</i>	Diagnostic	To identify the range of factors which inhibit people from seeking dental treatment. To generate ideas on ways of overcoming barriers.	108 dental attenders and non-attenders	Depth interviews (40) Group discussions (8)	12 months
<i>On Volunteering*</i>	Diagnostic and strategic	To identify and explore motivations to volunteer. To examine ways in which volunteers might be attracted and maintained.	70 volunteers and non-volunteers	Group discussions (8)	5 months
<i>Going on YTS: The Recruitment of Young People With Disabilities*</i>	Evaluative	To evaluate the processes of recruitment in terms of identification of young people with disabilities; their endorsement for special funding; their referral to suitable schemes. To identify good practice.	97 careers officers; government agency staff; managing agents; trainees	Depth interviews (67) Group discussions (4) Observational notes on training schemes provided	12 months

*These publications, based on particular studies, are listed with full details in the references.

familiarization,
identifying a thematic framework,
indexing,
charting,
mapping and interpretation (this being the stage at which the key objectives of qualitative analysis are addressed).

Each of these analytical stages is described and illustrated below.

Familiarization

Before beginning the process of sifting and sorting data, the researcher must become familiar with their range and diversity, must gain an overview of the body of material gathered. Although she or he will have been involved in some, if not all, of the data collection, and will have formed hunches about key issues and emergent themes, it is important at this stage to set these firmly in context by taking stock and gaining a feel for the material as a whole. Where more than one person has been involved in data collection, the analyst can have only a partial or 'second-hand' grasp of colleagues' material. Even where the analyst has been the sole interviewer, it is likely that recollections will be selective and partial.

Essentially, familiarization involves immersion in the data: listening to tapes, reading transcripts, studying observational notes. In some cases it is possible to review all the material at the familiarization stage, for example where only a few interviews have been carried out, or where there is a generous timetable for the research. However, more often than not in applied policy research, the timetable is too pressing or the volume of material too extensive, and a selection must be made for this initial stage.

How the material is selected will depend on a number of features of the data collection process, such as:

- the range of methods used,
- the number of researchers involved,
- the diversity of people and circumstances studied,
- the time period over which the material was collected,
- the extent to which the research agenda evolved or was modified during that time.

When making a selection, it is important to ensure that a range of different cases, sources, and time periods are reviewed. For example, in the study of barriers to dental care, material was collected by three researchers, through individual and group interviews amongst regular, intermittent and nonattenders. The analyst chose to review both individual and group data for different types of attenders and to include data collected by different researchers. For the study of sexual attitudes and behaviours, five researchers were involved in interviewing, partly to ease the interviewing burden, but also to evaluate the impact of interviewer characteristics, such as age and gender. Consequently, interviews were selected for review to include different interviewers at different stages of the fieldwork period as well as a mix of gender and age of respondents.

During the familiarization stage, the analyst listens to and reads through the material, listing key ideas and recurrent themes. Where a study aims to explore aspects of the research process as well as substantive issues, for example in the study of sexual attitudes and behaviour, notes are also made on the general atmosphere of the interview and the ease or difficulty of exploring particular subjects.

Identifying a Thematic Framework

During the familiarization stage, the analyst is not only gaining an overview of the richness, depth and diversity of the data, but also beginning the process of abstraction and conceptualization. While reviewing the material, the analyst will be making notes, recording the range of responses to questions posed by the researchers themselves, jotting down recurrent themes and issues which emerge as important to respondents themselves.

Once the selected material has been reviewed, the analyst returns to these research notes and attempts to identify the key issues, concepts and themes according to which the data can be examined and referenced. That is, she or he sets up a thematic framework within which the material can be sifted and sorted. When identifying and constructing this framework or index, the researcher will be drawing upon a priori issues (those informed by the original research aims and introduced into the interviews via the topic guide), emergent issues raised by the respondents themselves, and analytical themes arising from the recurrence or patterning of particular views or experiences.

The first version of an index is often largely descriptive and heavily rooted in a priori issues. It is then applied to a few transcripts when categories will be refined and become more responsive to emergent and analytical themes. For these refinements, the researcher looks for conceptualizations which encapsulate and represent diversity of experience, attitude, circumstance, etc.

Devising and refining a thematic framework is not an automatic or mechanical process, but involves both logical and intuitive thinking. It involves making judgements about meaning, about the relevance and importance of issues, and about implicit connections between ideas. In applied social policy research, it also involves making sure that the original research questions are being fully addressed.

The development of a thematic framework can be illustrated from the study of the living standards in unemployment, where one set of issues to be explored concerned patterns of expenditure in unemployment compared with those when last in work. This area of questioning (as outlined in the extract from the topic guide) and the emergent issues noted at the familiarization stage led to index categories as in Figure 12.2.

It will be seen that some of the index categories were virtually identical to specified areas of questioning (e.g. 1.3 Items and activities reduced); others were newly defined from the emergent themes (e.g. 1.5 Changing patterns over time). It should also be noted that the full index contained a total of 59 categories (i.e. 1.1, 2.1, 2.2, etc.), within 8 major subject headings.

Indexes provide a mechanism for labelling data in manageable 'bites' for subsequent retrieval and exploration. They should therefore not be overelaborate in detail at this stage as the analyst needs to retain an overview of all the categories. The more interpretative stages of analysis, which take place later, will produce the refinement of what is contained in each category.

If there is more than one population being studied (as, for example, in the case of the YTS [Youth Training Scheme] study), then it may be necessary to develop separate indexes for each group. Alternatively, it may be possible to keep a common index but deal with additional elements in the material through extra subcategories. Generally it is preferable to keep a common index for the different groups being studied as this helps immediately to identify both common and divergent themes.

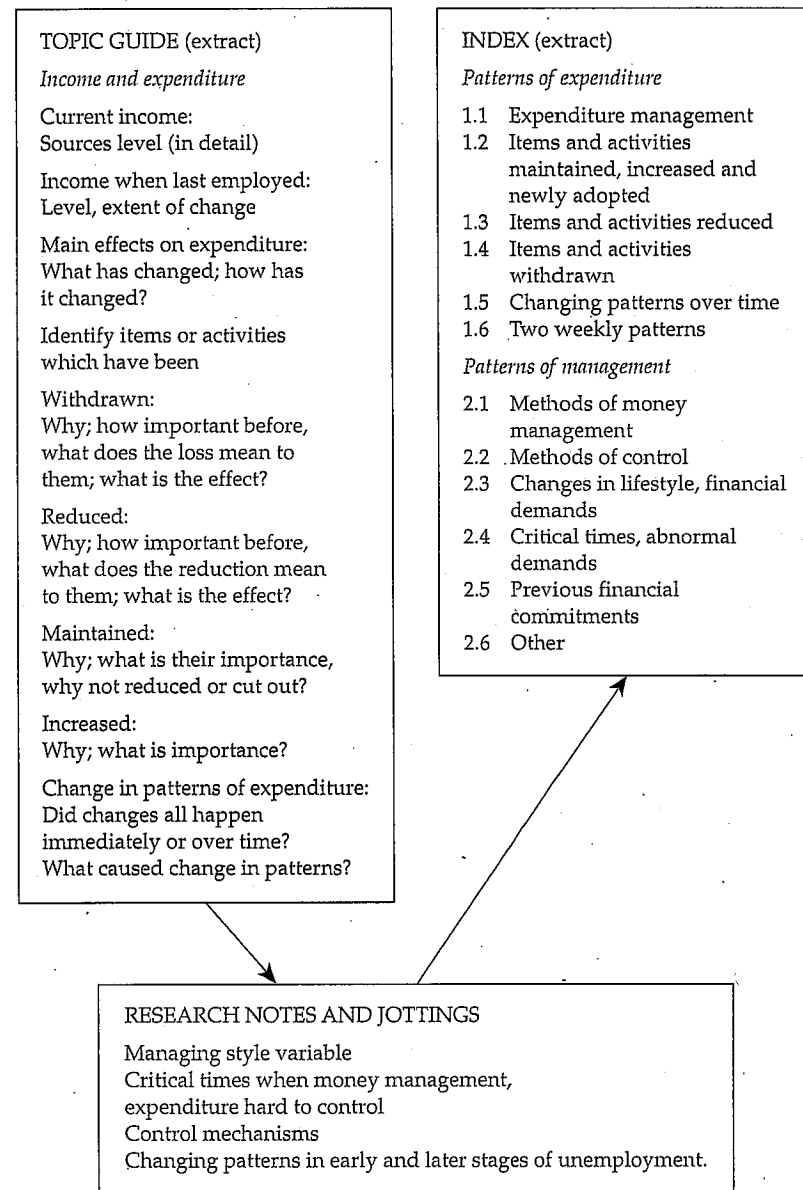


Figure 12.2 Development of a Thematic Framework

Indexing

'Indexing' refers to the process whereby the thematic framework or index is systematically applied to the data in their textual form. Although any textual material can be indexed in this way, the method has mainly been applied to transcriptions of individual and group interviews. All the data, not just those selected for review, are read and annotated according to the thematic framework. Indexing references are recorded on the margins of each transcript by a numerical system which links back to the index, or by a descriptive textual system based directly on the index headings.

Again, applying an index is not a routine exercise as it involves making numerous judgements as to the meaning and significance of the data. For each passage, the analyst must infer and decide on its meaning, both as it stands and in the context of the interview as a whole, and must record the appropriate indexing reference. Single passages often contain a number of different themes each of which needs to be referenced; multiple indexing of this kind can often begin to highlight patterns of association within the data. Of course, this process of making judgements is subjective, and open to differing interpretations. By adopting a system of annotating the textual data, however, the process is made visible and accessible to others; others can see for themselves how the data are being sifted and organized, research colleagues can 'try out' the framework and pool their experiences; the analyst can 'check out' the basis of his or her assumptions.

Figure 12.3 shows a page of an indexed transcript from the living standards study. The first column on the right-hand side replicates the index numbers assigned and any research notes that were made. The far column shows the content of the index categories to which these relate. These would not normally appear on the transcript but have been shown here for the purpose of clarification.

In Figure 12.3, it is possible to see that several different index prefixes appear on one page, even within one speech passage (e.g. 4.1, 1.3, 1.6, 1.4). It is quite common to find that different major topics are connected and interwoven in this way and this is one of the values of indexing. Once these are labelled, the analyst is able to access each reference and, more crucially, to see patterns and the contexts in which they arise. As already suggested, these juxtapositions are often one of the early clues to associations for subsequent stages of analysis.

F: We just live from day to day. Sometimes I make the kids pancakes if they're hungry and things like that where I never used to before. They could always go and help themselves to an extra bowl of cereal but the cereal has to be rationed, it's got to do. What I get at the weekend has to do for so many days. You know, things like that. And so, I say, fresh vegetable and fruit, I cut right down. Right down. And they all used to take an apple going to school, the older ones or a banana or an orange of something, they don't do that any more. Or I'd give them the money to get something extra at school. Can't do that any more. Just can't, it's just impossible. It's either that or we lose our home. Because they've already taken us before.	4.1 Impact on children 1.3 Items reduced 1.6 Two weekly patterns
M: County court.	
F: The county court and, as I say, it's £400 we're behind isn't it?	3.7 Loans/debts/arrears
M: What's that on?	1.3 Items reduced
F: Our mortgage, £400 isn't it?	
M: It was but over the last 2 months—er—we've got it, we've kept the last 10 months up to date, £72 per month. Next month and the following month we'll try and get off the arrears £30 per month, which is—	1.1 Expenditure management
F: Extra.	
M: (<i>baby shouting</i>) It's all more—I'm trying to say you're getting the tourniquet tightening on you all the while. That's why I'm hoping I can get a—with the weather, can get some work.	2.3 Changes in lifestyle/financial demands 7.1 Employment prospects
F: Yes, 2 months we've got.	

Figure 12.3 Example of an Indexed Transcript

Charting

Having applied the thematic framework to individual transcripts, the analyst needs to build up a picture of the data as a whole, by considering the range of attitudes and experience for each issue or theme. Data

are 'lifted' from their original context and rearranged according to the appropriate thematic reference. This process, referred to as charting, is described below.

Charts are devised with headings and subheadings which may be drawn from the thematic framework, from a priori research questions, or according to considerations about how best to present and write up the study. How the charts are laid out will depend on whether analysis is to be thematic (for each theme across all respondents) or by case (for each respondent across all themes). Where a thematic approach is adopted, charts are drawn up for each key subject area, and entries made for several respondents on each chart. The ordering and grouping of the individual cases may be linked to characteristics or dimensions that are known or believed to have a significant effect on patterns of experience or behaviour etc. The essential point, however, is that cases are always kept in the same order for each subject chart, so that the whole data set for each case can easily be reviewed. Where a case approach is used, one or two charts may be drawn up for each case, with subjects recorded in the same order.

In the case of the living standards study, a thematic approach was followed, and six major subject charts were constructed. These covered:

- patterns of management,
- patterns of expenditure,
- personal and social effects,
- effects on family life,
- standards of living (definition and changes),
- employment: activity, attitudes to and job search.

Figure 12.4 shows some of the headings for the chart 'Patterns of expenditure'. Several families were entered on each chart, grouped according to the ratio of their income in unemployment to that when last employed, known as the replacement ratio. By keeping a consistent order for the families on each chart, comparisons could be made between or within cases. It can also be seen that some of the chart headings were identical to index categories (e.g. Items reduced, Two weekly patterns), others reflected newly emergent themes identified while indexing the data (e.g. Periods of new control). For example, this latter heading was introduced to chart data about a period often described in the interviews when families had to introduce new levels of expenditure control.

CHART 3. PATTERNS OF EXPENDITURE FAMILIES WITH REPLACEMENT RATIO 75-90%				
Family	Items maintained	Items reduced	Two weekly patterns	Periods of new control
1				
2				
3 etc.				

Figure 12.4 Example of Subject Chart Headings

Whereas some methods of qualitative analysis rely on a 'cut and paste' approach, whereby 'chunks' of verbatim texts are regrouped according to their index reference, charting involves abstraction and synthesis. Each passage of text, which has been annotated with a particular reference, is studied and a distilled summary of the respondent's views or experiences is entered on the chart. The level of detail recorded varies between projects and between researchers, from lengthy descriptions to cryptic abbreviations for each entry. However, the original text is referenced so that the source can be traced and the process of abstraction can be examined and replicated. Illustrative passages for possible quotation are also referenced by transcript page numbers at this stage.

In the study of recruitment of young people with disabilities to YTS, one of the key subjects to be charted was the way in which different parties defined and interpreted the term 'disability'. Under the overall heading 'definitions of disability', further subheadings were elaborated to include: the 'official definition' (as endorsed by the government agency), the respondents' 'own definition', and 'grey areas' or ambiguities of interpretation or application. Charts were then constructed separately for each group of respondents: careers officers, agency staff and scheme providers. Transcripts were studied according to the appropriate index references, and a summary of each respondent's views entered on the chart. Figure 12.5 shows an example of the chart constructed for careers officers, and illustrates the kind of entries recorded together with the page referencing system.

Respondent	The recruitment of young people with disabilities to YTS CHART 3: DEFINITIONS OF DISABILITY (Careers Officers)		
	3.1 Official definition	3.2 Own definition	3.3 Grey areas
CO1	Includes physical sensory handicaps and learning difficulties. (p. 10) Area officers more flexible than the official guide-lines. (p. 18)	Also add moderate learning difficulties and behavioural problems. (p. 12) 'The naughty boys'. (p. 13)	What about people who are socially disadvantaged? (p. 22) Is inequality a disability? (p. 27) Official view would not accept this. (p. 29)
CO2	Physical/sensory/mental handicap + behavioural. (p. 15)	Go along with official view. Find it very helpful. (p. 19)	Problem is managing agents take a very narrow view—physical/sensory only—and the official statistics are based on their returns. (p. 27)
CO3			

Figure 12.5 Example of Subject Chart Entries

Mapping and Interpretation

When all the data have been sifted and charted according to core themes, the analyst begins to pull together key characteristics of the data, and to map and interpret the data set as a whole. Although emergent categories, associations and patterns will have been noted and recorded during the indexing and charting phases, the serious and systematic process of detection now begins. It is here that the analyst

returns to the key objectives and features of qualitative analysis outlined at the beginning of this chapter, namely:

defining concepts,
mapping range and nature of phenomena,
creating typologies,
finding associations,
providing explanations,
developing strategies, etc.

Which of these the analyst chooses to attempt will be guided by the original research questions to be addressed, and by the themes and associations which have emerged from the data themselves.

Whichever route is followed, the basic processes are the same: the analyst reviews the charts and research notes; compares and contrasts the perceptions, accounts, or experiences; searches for patterns and connections and seeks explanations for these internally within the data. Piecing together the overall picture is not simply a question of aggregating patterns, but of weighing up the salience and dynamics of issues, and searching for a structure rather than a multiplicity of evidence.

This part of the analytical process is the most difficult to describe. Any representation appears to suggest that the analyst works in a mechanical way, making obvious conceptualizations and connections, whereas in reality each step requires leaps of intuition and imagination. The whole process of immersion in the data triggers associations, the origins of which the analyst can scarcely recognize. Because this crucial part of the process is so difficult to encapsulate, a number of different examples are given below, and an attempt made to crystallize and convey the logical and creative pathways followed.

Defining Concepts

In the course of charting references to a particular phenomenon, the analyst may well have begun to identify a number of associated features or descriptions. At this stage, however, she or he systematically examines the charted material, searching for key dimensions and themes.

So, for example, in the living standards study, an analysis was undertaken of how the terms 'living standards' and 'standards of living' were defined by study participants. The case study families,

between them, identified nine factors that had a bearing on their judgements of living standards. These were:

the amount of disposable *income* they had,
the items of *expenditure* they could or could not afford,
the level of *choice* or constraint that surrounded their pattern of expenditure,
the level of *financial security* that was felt,
the degree of *struggle* involved in making ends meet,
the material *possessions* they had, or could attain,
the degree to which *expectations* were fulfilled,
the extent to which *self-esteem* could be upheld,
the feelings of *contentment* that surrounded life.

These elements emerged during the course of people describing their present standards of living, or what it had been like before, or how they defined a good or poor standard of living or simply their understanding of the term.

A further example of clarifying definitions is taken from the study of the recruitment to YTS of young people with disabilities, where identifying the range and diversity of concepts of disability was important in order to understand how guide-lines were implemented, and to gain an understanding of the recruitment process. By first listing the characteristics associated with disability, and then ordering them on the dimension of inclusivity-exclusivity, it was possible to devise a scale of definitions, and to identify how different labels were applied. Figure 12.6 illustrates this three-stage process.

Mapping the Range and Nature of Phenomena

A core function of qualitative research is to identify the form and nature of a phenomenon, and where appropriate, to map the polarities. In the study of volunteering, a central objective of the research was to identify key reasons why people might become volunteers. By reviewing the charts for references to attitudes, experiences, images and deterrents, it was possible to draw out key dimensions of motivations to volunteer (see Figure 12.7).

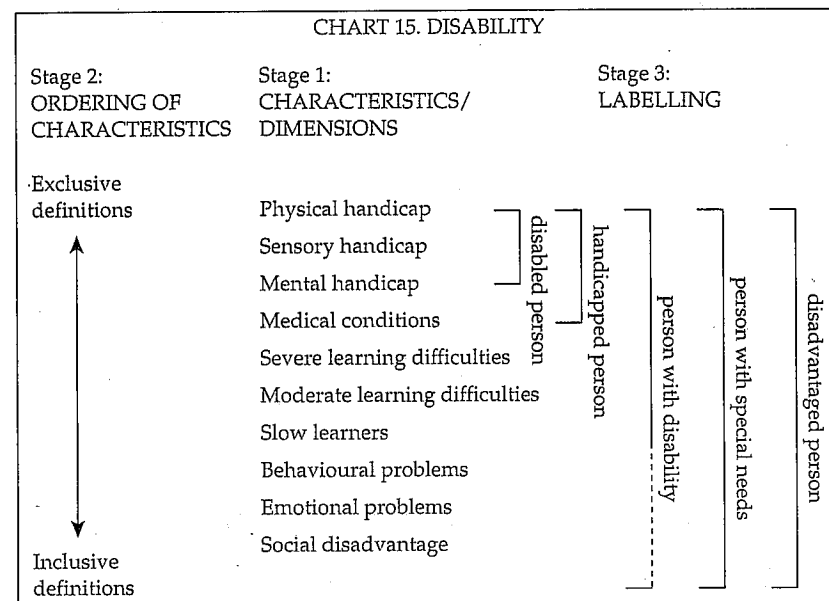


Figure 12.6 Process of Defining Dimensions of a Concept

Creating Typologies

Having identified key dimensions or characteristics of particular social phenomena, the researcher may decide to move on to multidimensional analysis, as in the creation of typologies, where two or more dimensions are linked at different points, giving a range of *types* of cases. In the study of sexual attitudes and behaviours, it was important to establish the nature of people's sexual histories and life-styles in order to understand the context of their views and actions. Key dimensions of sexual life-style were identified as the number of sexual partners over time, and the basis of the relationship(s) or encounter(s). By plotting people's histories and current sexual activity along these two dimensions, a typology of sexual life-styles could be constructed (see Figure 12.8).

Finding Associations

In the course of indexing and charting interview material the analyst may become aware of a patterning of responses; for example it may

Table 12.2 Plotting Associations

USE OF LABELS				
<i>Disabled Person</i>	<i>Handicapped Person</i>	<i>Person With a Disability</i>	<i>Person With Special Needs</i>	<i>Disadvantaged Person</i>
MA 1 (B)	MA 2 (B)	AS 1	CO 1	CO 3
MA 5 (B)	MA 3 (B)	AS 2	CO 5	CO 4
MA 8 (B)	MA 6 (B)	AS 3	CO 8	CO 6
	AS 6	AS 4	MA 4 (S)	CO 7
		CO 2	MA 7 (S)	
			AS 5	

Key: MA (B) = Managing agent for basic scheme

MA (S) = Managing agent for special scheme

CO = Career officer

AS = Agency staff

triggered the research in the first place, or to account for issues and patterns of behaviour which arise from the research itself.

In the study of sexual attitudes and behaviour, it emerged from the analysis that young heterosexual men and women, whose sexual lifestyles suggested they would be wise to practise safe sex, were taking no preventative measures at all. They did not consider themselves to be in a high risk group such as people who 'do drugs', or are 'promiscuous'. By unpacking how people defined the term promiscuous, it was possible to explain why people did not apply the label to themselves. Key characteristics associated with promiscuity were identified as:

- the basis of the relationship (casual),
- feelings about sexual partners (absence of),
- number of partners over time (compared with own experience),
- number of partners co-terminously (more than one).

It became clear that whereas others were described as promiscuous on any one of these counts, people did not label their own behaviour in this way unless all the conditions applied. So, for example, people who had casual sexual encounters or more than one partner at a time did not consider themselves promiscuous if they liked their partners and judged them to be 'nice people'; people who changed partners every few months felt they were exempt because the relationship was 'serious' while it lasted, and so on.

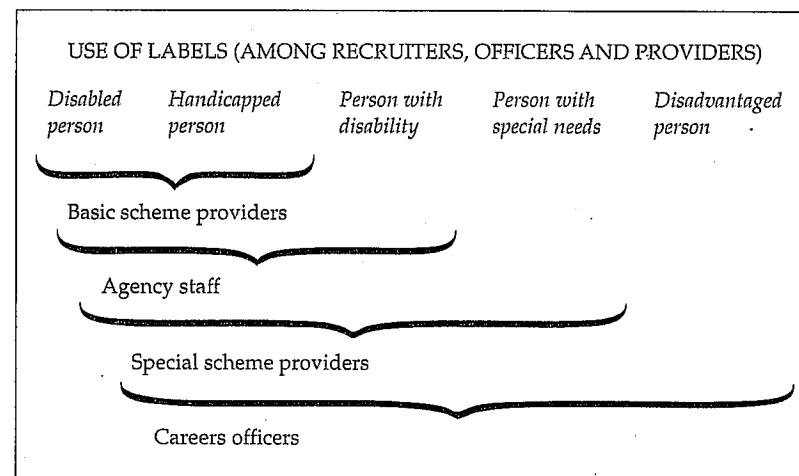


Figure 12.9 Mapping Patterns

Developing Strategies

Much of the research carried out in the policy field has a strategic component; policy-makers commission research into attitudes, behaviours and experiences because they wish to inform their policy decisions. As a result of the process of analyzing qualitative data, and identifying underlying motivations, patterns and explanations, it may be possible to develop strategies for change which arise directly from the qualitative material itself. For example, the volunteering study identified a number of positive and negative conditions which accounted for whether or not people became volunteers. By drawing out the implications of these conditions, it was possible to develop a strategy for attracting and retaining volunteers which directly addressed those issues (see Figure 12.10).

A second example is provided by the dental health study, where a number of barriers to dental care were identified. These in turn led to the formulation of a number of specific strategies that would help people become more regular attenders. Some of these arose out of explicit suggestions made by the respondents themselves, others were derived indirectly from the nature of the problems. So, for example, one key area concerned the cost of dental treatment; specific suggestions made in relation to this were:

ATTRACTING AND RETAINING VOLUNTEERS

change perceptions

need for positive, interesting, caring image, to overcome unprofessional, 'busybody', amateur connotations

practical incentives and help

training

reimbursement for travel expenses

higher profile

provide more information

give a focus for information e.g. identifiable agency

modes of recruitment

personal invitation/overcoming resistance to compulsory schemes

Figure 12.10 Developing Strategies

reduce or abolish dental charges,
introduce a clear charging system,
inform patients of the cost of treatment before commitment to carrying it out,
ensure privacy when determining eligibility for free treatment,
(for long-term attenders) provide an incentive of first course of treatment free.

❖ CONCLUSIONS

Because of the nature of SCPR's work, we (and other researchers with us) have had the opportunity to apply 'Framework' on numerous studies. The method, of course, needs to be adapted to suit the aims and coverage of a specific piece of research, but it has proved flexible for a range of different types of studies. It has been applied to in-depth and group interviewing, longitudinal studies, case studies, and projects involving different groups or subpopulations of participants. 'Framework' has also been successfully used jointly by two or more researchers working on a single project, in some cases cross-institutionally.

It will perhaps be apparent that some parts of the process have been relatively easy to display, while others have been much more difficult to capture. Nevertheless, we believe these more elusive stages,

particularly those which involve inductive and interpretative thinking, can be made explicit in some form. As already emphasized, we believe this accessibility is important for those who commission and use qualitative research for public policy purposes.

We wish to stress that the analysis method described above is just one approach for synthesizing and interpreting qualitative data. Although it does accommodate all the features we believe to be important, there are certainly other approaches that would equally satisfy these requirements. But, until recently, this has been difficult to know since qualitative researchers have not made their analytic tools accessible. It is important that individual researchers provide documentation of their methods and techniques of analysis, not just in volumes of this kind, but also in research publications and proposals. Only by so doing will the research community widen its pool of analytic knowledge and extend its methodological base.

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